

UTTAR PRADESH

PITCHES ITSELF AS TOP ECO TOURIST DESTINATION

Uttar Pradesh with its 16620 sq km forest area is home to some exquisitely beautiful landscapes, forest-vistas, meandering rivers and breathtakingly beautiful waterfalls and a large number of endangered birds and animals. There are forest dwelling tribes and communities who have maintained their traditions and culture while embracing modern technologies and life-styles. There is one national park, 11 wild life sanctuaries and 24 bird sanctuaries to provide protection to endangered biodiversity of the state. Some bird sanctuaries have been declared important bird areas by the Bombay Natural History Society.

The Uttar Pradesh Forest Department, with help from experts, has grouped the existing 37 potential destinations under nine circuits. In a resolve that aims to uplift the locals' "well-being" and to boost the tourism sector in the state, UP Tourism Department have roped in people who are being trained as guides and in cooking, housekeeping, with some focus, interestingly, on women of Tharu ethnicity who are being trained to use forest produce and waste to make jewellery.

For the tourists, the government has made available the facility to book tickets online for Dudhwa, Katarniaghat, Motipur and Kakraha forest areas. The government is hoping to increase tourism in Uttar Pradesh through these nine circuits. Some selected eco-tourism packages attracted a large number of tourists, which prompted the government to prop up the lesser-known sanctuaries, waterfalls, wildlife and forest areas. "The idea is to draw visitors to natural areas keeping in mind their conservation and at the same time improve the well-being of the locals," The nine Circuits includes

LION SAFARI & RIVERINE CIRCUIT

The Lion Safari & Riverine Circuit, which offers visitors trip to Bear Resque Facility and Taj Nature Walk (both in Agra), and National Chambal Sanctuary and Lion Safari (both in Etawah).

TERAI TIGER CIRCUIT

The Terai Tiger Circuit would take you through Chuka Tiger Reserve (Pilibhit), Kishanpur Wildlife Sanctuary, Dudhwa National Park and Katarniaghat Wildlife Sanctuary.

EASTERN / WESTERN WILDLIFE CIRCUIT

The Eastern Wildlife Circuit covers trips to Suhelwa Wildlife Sanctuary, Sohagi Barwa Wildlife Sanctuary and Parvati Arga Bird Sanctuary, the Western Circuit covers Amangarh (Bijnor), Shivalik (Saharanpur) and Hastinapur Wildlife Sanctuary, which allows tourists to traverse through hills, undertake wild safari rides, and take nature walks while sighting tiger, elephants, sloth bear and wild boar as well as about 300 species of birds.

GANGES BASIN CIRCUIT

The Ganges Basin Circuit includes visit to Narora Dam, Bulandshahr where one can sight dolphins along the Ganga and visit to Kannauj and Bithoor range in Kanpur.

BUNDELKHAND ADVENTURE CIRCUIT

The Bundelkhand Adventure Circuit aims at promoting tourism in the region by providing water sports, adventure tours in Vindhya and Satpura range, visits to Kalinjar fort in Banda as well as Devgarh fort and Rajghat Dam in Lalitpur, along with a pilgrimage tour to Chitrakoot.

VINDHYA MOUNTAIN CIRCUIT

The Vindhya Mountain Circuit would cover trip to Fossil Park, Ancient Cave paintings etc in Kaimoor Wildlife Sanctuary. It also Cover Chandraprabha Wildlife Sanctuary, Hathinala (Renukoot), Vijaygarh (Sonbhadra), Chunar / Vindham (Mirzapur)

Western and Central Bird / Wetland Circuits

The Western and Central Bird / Wetland Circuits would cover various bird sanctuaries and identified wetlands that fall in the western and central part of the state. Okhla Bird Sanctuary, Surajpur Wetland, Patna Wildlife Sanctuary, Sarsai Navar Wetland, Saman Wildlife Sanctuary and Soor Sarovar Bird Sanctuary covers in Western Bird / Wetland Circuit and Nawabganj Bird Sanctuary, Sandi Bird Sanctuary, Samaspur Bird Sanctuary and Lakh Bhahosi Bird Sanctuary covers in Central Bird / wetland Circuit. A large number of migratory birds move to these region each year.

Along with promoting nature walks, UP Tourism Department focus is also on promoting conservation at these destinations.

